Big Enough

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/57689368.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Western AU, AU, AU Roulette Challenge 2024, Oneshot, sapphic romance - Freeform, Enemies to Lovers, Friends to Enemies to Lovers, twist ending, Cliffhanger

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by princesscolumbia

Summary

Adora has grown tired of the fight against The Horde, the most notorious gang to rise up in the aftermath of the Civil War. She lost her friend to The Horde's propaganda, lost Glimmer's mother to The Horde's machinations, and was betrayed by her mentor Light Hope. Now she just wants to live out her life on the homestead she built in the Wild West. Surprises abound and the call of duty stirs her from her depression, but the return of her oldest enemy will bring her reconciliation that she never even dreamed she'd have.

Notes

Back into the She-ra-verse! Just a one-shot, though if I *do* become a professional writer and wind up with nothing but time to write on my hands, I'll probably spend some time turning this into a multichap.

See the end of the work for more notes

Adora squinted into the sunset as she rode westerly, letting her horse take a relaxed, leisurely gait. A year ago, she'd rode this same route for the first time, feeling the trepidation of going somewhere she'd never been and unsure if she'd recognize it, but also the weariness to not really care if it was the right place or not. She'd just wanted to reach the end of her own, personal road and settle down on a nice, large square of property that she could build a cabin on and live in peace.

Eleven months ago she'd charged down this road pel-mel, pushing Swift Wind as hard as he could go, chasing a phantom from her past and terrified that the life she'd hoped to live might be snatched out from under her before she'd even dug out the foundation of her cabin properly.

Ten months ago she rode this path with one hand on her pistol, half-cocked in the holster, eyes scanning the prairie land around her for any possible hint of ambush. The foe she'd been forced to call a truce with was as terrifyingly cunning as she was opportunistic. Adora wouldn't have put it past her long-time foe to have dug out a trap or found less...earthly means of hiding her presence until it was too late.

Nine months ago Adora had done something she'd never imagined; carried an injured girl down this road to the only person in the territory, possibly the only person on the continent, that could...that *would* help her. It had been a near thing, the girl had been injured by Adora's own bullet and due to the nature of the girl and the bullet, the poor thing had nearly bled out by the time she'd gotten the help she needed to live.

Eight months ago she'd begrudgingly packed up all her special ammunition in a weighty satchel and rode into town to deliver it as a peace offering. Adora wouldn't start trouble with her particularly lethal ammunition, and the already established population wouldn't drive her off the land she was building up as her own. Adora had already put enough miles under her all up and down the East coast in pursuit of her "big destiny," now that

she had a plot of land all her own she was hesitant to leave. Also, the woman she'd held up in her mind as an enemy was turning out to be not that bad, all things considered.

Seven months ago, she had been wearing her finest dress and riding side-saddle on Swift Wind to her first social event in the small town of Prariedog. She'd spent half the night tight as a wire and watching her seemingly life-long foe for any signs of trouble. She needn't have bothered, though it took her hindsight to really realize it. The dance was fun, and the guests had been there to have a good time. Nobody was threatened or injured, and she even saw a couple of budding romances begin. Had she danced? Maybe. But strictly for surveillance purposes. *Someone*, she had thought at the time, had to keep an eye on the woman who was still the third most wanted gang leader in 13 states. That was the only reason, honest.

Six months ago, she'd been too sick to move, so her horse had taken the trip into town without her. Dumb horse. Naturally, Swift Wind's presence in town, no saddle and no rider, had raised an alarm or three. Imagine her fever-fueled terror to find the woman who'd sworn she'd one day kill Adora walking into the small, utilitarian bedroom she'd built for herself. Adora *knew* she was going to die, if not from the fever, then from a knife through her heart. Neither predicted death happened, and that was when she realized that maybe she might have been wrong about her one-time nemesis.

Five months ago, she'd taken the trip for no reason in particular. She had her storehouse built, she didn't have any supplies coming in from the travelling couriers that stopped in Prariedog on their way to destinations further west, like the goldrush city of Denver or the religious settlements like Salt Lake. She had no real reason to make the trip, but she'd done so with a smile on her face and humming the occasional tune. She couldn't have told you why.

Four months ago she'd made the trip at, once again, a break-neck speed. She'd been desperate to get to town before her friends arrived via stagecoach. She'd only gotten word because Frosta

had seen that she hadn't picked up her post in a couple weeks and made the trek to Adora's homestead to drop it off personally. Adora hadn't even gotten to her mail for hours after that visit, reading the letter by lamplight that Glimmer was taking a break from her duties as head of the Church in New York and bringing her new husband Bow with her. If Glimmer saw the mayor before Adora could intervene, the town of Prariedog would be wiped off the map for no other crime than two women who'd been at war for years happened to pick it seemingly at random and had come to an accord that meant the tiny town thrived.

Three months ago she'd rode into town at the crack of dawn, new sheriffs badge pinned to her vest. The townsfolk had come to know and respect her, a few even having visited her home a couple times (prompting Adora to build an extension to her cabin containing a game room...wouldn't Casta be scandalized...and a guest bedroom so her visitors wouldn't have to make the trek back to town or their homestead in the dark). She hadn't even really wanted to be sheriff, but knew she was the best person for the job, both by training and because she had grown to care for the town and its people.

Two months ago she'd made the trip with the notorious outlaw Charlie "Tongue Lashor" Baker in tow, hands firmly cuffed and riding sullenly on the back of his horse. It'd been a fine horse, too. Fine enough that the mayor confiscated it for her personal use, making sure "Tongue Lashor" (*Goddess, what a stupid name!* she thought, *What in the world was he thinking when he came up with it?)* was well aware of what she was doing as he was loaded up in the prisoner transport wagon from Fort Worth to be taken to the county seat for trial. Adora had been quite pleased with that particular arrest and hadn't thought anything of it when a reporter asked her a few questions and took a picture of her with a tintype camera.

One month ago, she'd taken this same path to let the mayor know that there was trouble heading there way. Someone both of them had reason to fear was heading to Prariedog. Apparently, the tintype had made it to the major papers back East, a photogenic

sheriff bringing in a notorious (if stupidly named) outlaw was big enough news to make it all the way across the continent...at least one newspaper with her picture landed in the hands of the *second* most notorious gang leader in 13 states.

Adora had sent messages to Glimmer and Bow and Casta and even Micah, hoping that they could help by catching the woman known as "The Shadow Weaver" thanks to a particularly clever reporter and the notoriety of her criminal network. Like the shadows she was purported to be able to manipulate, she was too elusive and, in spite of the best efforts of the church and the police force of New York operating under the direction of Governor Micah Moon, Shadow Weaver was on her way out West. Adora had reached out to the native tribes for assistance, and through them got word of a large group just an hour prior, possibly as many as thirty of Shadow Weaver's people were coming in via horseback from the south.

Adora rode through the darkened town, most of the citizens fleeing to the settlement homes on the surrounding farms and ranches. More than a few people who normally lived in the rooms above or behind their shops on the town's one street had joined their fellow townsfolk on the plains. Adora was grateful, there were really only a handful of people in town that should be confronting Shadow Weaver and her crew, and that included her, the town brothel, and the mayor.

The brothel and the saloon next door to it were the only two buildings in town that had any lights on, liquid fuel lanterns keeping the places bright enough to navigate in the pitch dark of night that existed wherever the light pollution of the city didn't touch.

Adora hitched Swift Wind to the post in front of the saloon, pausing to look across the street to the sheriff's office the town had built for her, wishing for even the briefest of moments that she'd had more people with a badge and the training needed for the threat that was bearing down on the town. But then, she wouldn't wish her youth, growing up in the streets and alleys of

Philadelphia with the girl that would later become her worst enemy or her training under Light Hope when she'd turned away from the life that her one-time best friend had embraced whole-heartedly, on anybody. Long nights where you weren't sure if you'd even wake up the next morning if you fell asleep, disease, lack of food, and all controlled by Shadow Weaver. Then she landed in what she thought was the best thing possible for an orphan; the executor of her family's estate, the family she didn't even know she belonged to, recognized her from a birthmark most people didn't see, a pattern on her chest she tried to keep hidden because it felt so...*ugly* to have the half-circle of blotchy markings on her skin. The woman had only seen it because Adora's old shirt had started falling apart at the seams (Shadow Weaver refused to pay for more than one shirt a year for the orphans in her care, even during their growth spurts of their teenage years) when she'd been trying to sneak through the family estate's garden.

By the time she'd managed to get some free time to herself, she tracked down her old friend to tell her the good news; she was no longer homeless, she had a place to live and could bring her friend in from the cold and they wouldn't have to stay hidden anymore.

The friend who'd taken one look at the fine, custom tailored clothes, the token of the church (gifted to Adora by the head of New York's church herself, Angella) hanging from her neck, and the brightly shining six-shooter hanging from Adora's hip and rejected her. Adora's heart still clenched as she remembered the unbridled anger and hatred from the girl she'd have given the world, the word 'traitor' being the most frequently used before declaring before everyone in the slums of Philly known as 'The Fright Zone' that Adora was officially an enemy.

That had been the start of a campaign of years where the two were almost evenly matched for victories and defeats. Adora became one of the best law bringers in the fledgling nation, breaking the grip of the gangs that had risen in the aftermath of the Civil War just a few years prior. She, along with her friends

Glimmer and Bow, had made a name for themselves even before they turned 18 for cleaning up city after city up and down the coast. Bow named them, "The Best Friends Squad," and they'd remained true to the title...

...until The Horde assassinated Angella, who also happened to be Glimmer's mother.

Word on the street was it had been orchestrated by Gregory "Hordak" Fitzgerald, former Confederate soldier who had lost a leg in the war. And sure, it had been his train that had exploded, but Angella wasn't even supposed to be *on* the train.

Adora was.

Because the train, boldly called *The Portal to the West*, was supposed to be the ultimate war machine, mounted gatling guns with armored turrets and a nearly unstoppable 150 tons of iron and steam. Built from Hordak's plans by the former Union engineer Emily Trapp, the woman had fallen in deep with The Horde and had been part of the plan to capture Adora and hold her prisoner aboard the engine of the train for its initial run, which was supposed to double as its first deployment as a military vehicle, holding Philadelphia hostage until the Church and Federal government both capitulated. Plans for a whole fleet of the trains were scrapped, however, because Emily had found a flaw, one that wasn't readily apparent during the design and building phase. When she tried to explain the problem to the woman holding Adora captive, Emily had been incapacitated and ordered removed from the train. The lever releasing the brakes on the massive war machine had been pulled by the hand of the woman who'd once been Adora's best friend, and it started down the tracks.

Angella had already boarded, meeting with Hordak directly to attempt to negotiate, at the very least, Adora's release and eventual terms of de-escalation, but with Hordak's second-in-command starting the train, talks immediately broke down. Glimmer and Bow led a strike team to board the train before it started moving too fast and it became a running firefight, The

Horde trying to keep the boarders from making headway toward the engine while Angella took advantage of Hordak's distraction to find and release Adora.

By the time Angella had undone the bindings on Adora, they were alone in the cabin of the engine and both noticed the train was going faster and faster. The problem Emily had found was a flaw in the governor, it would allow the train to burn hotter and hotter until the pressure in the steam cylinder would cause the whole thing to explode. The two women hatched a plan to hold the brakes on to slow the train so it would only blow while on a bridge that spanned the Delaware river that ran through the city. Whoever held the brake would die, and Angella said she would decouple the cars from the engine but would need help to do so.

It was a lie, one that saved Adora's life. Angella had attempted to knock Adora out, but the younger woman was only dazed. The head of the church tearfully apologized and took advantage of Adora's incapacity to decouple the cars and ride the engine down the tracks. The plan worked, the train was isolated from the population of the city on the bridge when it blew, leaving an injured Adora to explain to Glimmer how her mother had died.

The incident had broken both The Horde and the Best Friends Squad. Hordak went into seclusion, leaving the running of his 'empire' to his lieutenants, one of whom disappeared and was presumed dead, the other letting Horde territory shrink back down to *just* The Fright Zone in Philadelphia.

Glimmer took over her mother's post in the Church and worked with her father to clean up in the wake of the retreating Horde.

And Adora had fled, selling her family's house and holdings and moving out to the Wild West, hoping to forget...only for the woman who she'd watch set the events in motion that would kill Angella to become mayor of the town Adora had fled to.

Adora shook her head, trying to clear the memories of triumphs and tragedies that felt like they were from another life entirely

and entered the saloon.

The mayor was already there, of course. Since she ran the brothel next door and was one of the major defenders of the tiny populous, she wouldn't be anywhere else. Adora settled her weight on the stool next to her friend-turned-enemy-turned-...what, coworker? Working acquaintance?

She nodded at the bartender, a hulking brute of a woman who'd been ordered to remove Emily from the Horde...and the pair had fled together, landing themselves in the tiny town. Sandra "The Scorpion" Friggasdottr nodded back and, without a word, began pouring Adora's usual.

Adora pulled her gun from the holster and set it on the bar, absently disengaging the cylinder and pulling the bullets from it, "Did you bring it?" she asked without looking at the other woman.

The mayor wordlessly reached under her poncho and hefted a not insubstantial bag onto the counter, the contents clinking dully in the quiet saloon.

Adora pulled the knot holding the bag closed loose and tugged it open. She sighed as she dug her fingers into the bag to start digging out the bullets contained inside. "I'm sorry..." she said quietly as she began reloading her revolver with the special ammo.

The mayor lifted her glass of whiskey to her lips and said, "For what?" before taking a sip of the amber liquid.

"I promised you I'd never use this ammo in the town limits."

"Aint your fault Shadow Weaver's on her way."

The Scorpion put the glass of Adora's preferred drink, a bourbon, in front of her. Adora gave the larger woman a restrained smile and nod as she continued to fill the chambers of her revolver. To the mayor, she said, "I was the fool that stood still long enough

for a tintype. Weaver probably wouldn't have ever put two and two together if I'd just given a statement without a picture."

The other woman sipping alcohol snorted, "It's a good picture, a good likeness. Be a damn shame to not have your face on the page."

Having nothing to say to that, Adora reached down and undid the ties that held her ammo bag to her thigh and hefted it onto the bar top. She quietly and methodically pulled the normal ammunition she kept on her person out of the bag, each cluster of six bullets tied together with twine so she wouldn't have to count out each bullet while trying to reload in the field. Emily had talked about making some form of "speed reloader," but until the scientist could manage it without causing an explosion, Adora was satisfied with her makeshift bundles.

As she worked the bullets out of the string and replaced them with the special ammunition one at a time, she said, "I'm sorry anyway...for...a lot."

She could *feel* the incredulously raised eyebrow aimed at her, "...such as?"

"For...I guess, assuming you wanted the same things I did as a kid. I wanted to get out and into a better life so bad...I thought you did to."

The clack of an empty glass tumbler on the bar top was echoed with a, "Ha! Of *course* I wanted *out*. I wasn't stupid. What I *wanted* was for us to make it out *together*, not for you to disappear, get me blamed for it, then have you become the church's bitch."

Adora blushed, not looking up from her task, "Yeah, well, we both know how that went, don't we?"

"No," came the response as Sandra refilled the glass with more whiskey, "I don't. The Horde never really got the full story and

Hordak and Weaver never cared enough. What happened between you and the church, anyway?"

"Light Hope," Adora sneered as the Quaker name came out of her mouth for the first time in years, "She decided I wasn't good *enough*, kept pushing me harder and harder and when I pushed back...she moved on to Glimmer. Manipulated her just like Weaver used to do with us. When I confronted her about it, she let slip that *she'd* been the one that orphaned me. Apparently, my folks weren't faithful *enough* for her."

The mayor let out a quiet whistle, "...damn, you just lucked out with the mother figures, didn't you?"

Adora snorted, still intent on her task, "At least Shadow Weaver didn't *hide* that she hated you. She may have been a bitch, but she wore it proudly."

"Mmm," the sound of whiskey being sipped reminded Adora she had bourbon waiting for her, "And what happened with Light Hope?"

Adora took a sip of her own drink, "I tried to arrest her for murder, she wouldn't come quietly, said it was her 'goddess given duty' to train up the next champion since I was such a disappointment. Drew a gun on me."

The mayor cackled, a nasty sound that nonetheless warmed Adora's heart a bit, "Fucked around and found out, did she?"

Adora snorted before taking another sip of bourbon, "Yup. I left town that night. Only Glimmer and Bow knew where I was going."

"Well, you smartened up there at the end, I guess. Too bad Weaver's back in our lives again."

Adora sighed and reached into her ammo bag only to discover she didn't have any more bundles of bullets. She began the process of putting the bundles back in the satchel, "Well, you always were the smarter of us."

"Nah." Surprised, Adora looked up to see Katherine's mismatched eyes, one blue, one hazel, looking back at her from a sad expression, "If I was smart I wouldn't have joined The Horde's inner circle."

"Wait, really? I thought you *liked*...?" she waved a hand to indicate 'all of you' to Katherine's form.

"Oh, I *do*, the whole thing did me right. But because of it I made the stupidest decisions ever. I...I was so angry at you, and I..." she sighed and her gaze dropped to the bar surface, "I'm the reason your friend's mom is dead."

Adora put a hand gently on Katherine's, "Kat, she's your friend now, too."

"...I guess. Only for you, though."

Adora blinked in confusion, "...what?"

"After you and Bow left to help Natasha find her wife, you remember?" Adora nodded, recalling how Bow had jumped at the chance to help Adora in the act that would eventually secure the town's decision to make her the sheriff. The two of them were convinced they'd return to find Katherine and Glimmer at each other's throats, only to find the pair of them laughing over a shared drink and thick as thieves. "Well, while you two were playing frontier heroes, Glimmer and I were almost killing each other for days. It wasn't until we started bitching about how annoying *you* were that we started realizing that we had as much in common as we do."

Adora smiled at Katherine with a snort, "I'll say, you two are practically each other's mirror image."

"Bitch, *I'm* the better looking one!" the words were angry, but the tone was laughing and they were delivered with a smile.

Adora blushed, "...yeah. Don't tell Glimmer I said so, but you are."

Unable to believe she said that, Adora's eyes dropped and she realized she was still holding Katherine's hand. Suddenly feeling awkward, Adora turned back to re-packing her bag with her ammo.

A few minutes later, she had finished her task and strapped the thigh pack back on. Not having anything better to do with it, she gathered the bullets she'd just removed from her gun and ammo bag and dumped it into the bag with her special ammo. She slid it over to the mayor, who gave her a curious look. "I...made a promise. Shadow Weaver's making me break that promise, but I can at least show you I mean it by giving you the rest back. I'd have melted it down if you hadn't insisted I not destroy it."

Katherine gently pushed the bag back to Adora, "And you've proven you're not just a puppet of the church anymore. I don't have to worry about you, I probably never did."

Tears springing into her eyes for reasons she didn't want to examine, Adora picked up the sack of ammo, hoping she wouldn't need to sift through the standard and special ammo in the heat of battle. If things went well tomorrow night, then she wouldn't need to worry about it. *Could probably go through and separate the two types of ammo in my office after sunrise tomorrow*, she thought.

She headed to the saloon doors, Katherine hopping off her barstool to walk with her. Just before Adora pushed the doors open, Katherine grabbed her arm, "Adora...stay with me tonight."

The breath rushed out of Adora's lungs all at once. "But...why? I..."

"You...I know we're both good. I mean, *really* good. You're the church's chosen avatar, their 'She-ra'," Katherine rolled her eyes at the title, which she had made very well known that she considered it to be very stupid, "I'm Hordak's lieutenant that fought him to a standstill."

"...really?!" blurted Adora.

Katherine rolled her eyes, "Yes, I'll tell you about it sometime...if we survive, because this is *Shadow Weaver*. She knows us better than we know ourselves, she can get under our skin and make us dance to her tune. And...I know now that you...never hated me."

Adora felt like there was a lump in her throat. She swallowed thickly and said, "I *never* hated you! I thought *you* hated *me!*"

It was Katherine's turn to get tears in her eyes. "Don't you get it? I love you. I always have. So please, just this once, stay," she said with a sad chuckle.

There was a 'thunk' as the bag of ammunition fell to the floor, "You...love me?"

Katherine chuckled, shaking her head wryly, "You're such an idiot."

Adora reached out, the distance of inches felt like miles as her fingers brushed Katherine's face, "I love you, too!" she almost squeaked out.

Katherine lifted her own hand to Adora's and pushed it so it was fully in contact with her jawline, then lifted both hands to gently cup Adora's head and pull the taller woman down. Their lips met and time seemed to freeze for her. Her arms circled the smaller woman's waist, pulling Katherine close, her body heat making its way through the heavy wool poncho and Adora's duster.

Eventually, the separated at the lips but their arms stayed around each other. Katherine smiled up at the girl that had been her friend and then her enemy and now, maybe her lover? A twinkle seemed to sneak into her eye as she grinned, "Why don't you call me the nickname you gave me when we were kids?"

Adora smirked, crouching down to pick up the bag half full of silver bullets and half full of lead ammo, straightened, and said, "Because 'Catra' is a weird name for a werewolf."

Catra snickered, her fangs showing in her smile, "Maybe I'm a weird werewolf?"

"Yeah, I mean, what kind of werewolf gives a hunter silver bullets?"

Catra leaned against Adora's chest, her canid ear twitching in the light of the nearly full moon streaming through the saloon doors, "The kind of werewolf that trusts her girl to use those silver bullets on the vampire riding into town."

"Point," replied Adora as they turned to leave. Instead of climbing back on her horse, she unhitched Swift Wind from the hitching post in front of the saloon and led him around the brothel, Catra in her arm, as they made their way to the 'Madam's Entrance' leading to Catra's private apartment.

End Notes

Fun fact, I wrote the DYGIILYIAHSPFJTOS part from memory. Yes, the She-ra brainrot is real and forever. 😁

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!